my parents' world, though I lost myself very happily for a time in keeping my own hive of bees.

My mother and stepfather split up when I was nine. It didn't seem so devastating at the time, but it represents, with the benefit of hindsight, the end of a relatively paradisical period in my life. As I said, there had been a Tom Sawyer feeling at the centre of my young years, a beautiful world of discovery, and the adventures of the near future would be altogether darker. Many of us see the safe environs of early childhood in a halo of light, and, for me, despite our rapid coming and going, our many houses and my hatred of school, those years were lived in a state of natural illumination. The world was fresh and the ocean was clear and the air smelled of the white gum tree. But human nature is more complicated, of course, than its physical setting, and life would not be life if it didn't cede to dark complications. Brett had his own struggles and, eventually, my mother couldn't cope with him any more, so we moved to a flat above a shop-front in Lismore that my mother shared with the Nomad Theatre Company. Mum often earned money as a face painter at markets, and later on my younger half-brother and I would trundle along. For a while I took up a mouth organ and played the pre-adolescent blues.

My mother and I had tried to live respectably in town, but we were about to embark on a peripatetic life largely fuelled by anxiety, drifting once more down the Mississippi. We would see a lot of Australia over the next few years – we'd seen a certain amount already – but for at least five years we felt pursued, and I suppose those years, as much as the happy years before, shaped the kind of person I was to become in the future. Our life with Brett had brought sunshine and art, music and nature, into our everyday experience. Brett's theatre productions, the way they could be rolled out and packed up in no time at all, was good preparation for WikiLeaks, but the next part, the part involving a man called Leif Meynell, would show us what it was like to be pursued by shadowy forces. He was my first tail.